

How Polarization Weakens the Foreign Policy of Democracies

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Abstract

In *Polarization and International Politics: How Extreme Partisanship Threatens Global Stability*, Rachel Myrick provides a groundbreaking and compelling understanding of how political divisions hamper the foreign policy performance of democracies. While a large literature has found that democracy enables a country's foreign policy to be more stable, credible, and reliable, Myrick explains that these democratic advantages disappear when a country becomes extremely polarized. Myrick supports her argument effectively with original cross-national data and in-depth analysis of U.S. foreign policy. The book generates many avenues for further research, including on whether the harmful foreign policy effects of polarization are reversible; whether related phenomena such as politicization, populism, and democratic erosion involve similar pathologies; and whether polarized fault lines within countries are being replicated in polarized political alignments among countries. This review article also discusses possible institutional, electoral, and interpersonal remedies to polarization, concluding that each of those has limitations and that a broad political movement may be necessary to reverse the polarization tide.

Keywords: polarization; partisanship; foreign policy; democracy; credibility; reputation

Polarization is widely recognized as one of the most important and concerning features of political life in the twenty-first century. Ezra Klein has aptly called it the “master story” of contemporary American politics,¹ and many studies have found that it marks both domestic and foreign policy debates in the United States.² Scholars have also shown that while levels of polarization vary across countries, polarization has been on the rise in much of the world. In an extensive cross-national study, Thomas Carothers and Andrew O'Donohue observed that polarization “is a widespread phenomenon, with common negative consequences for democracy across diverse national contexts.”³

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¹ Ezra Klein, *Why We're Polarized* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2020), xix.

² C. James DeLaet and James M. Scott, “Treaty-Making and Partisan Politics: Arms Control and the U.S. Senate, 1960–2001,” *Foreign Policy Analysis* 2, no. 2 (2006): 177–200; Charles A. Kupchan and Peter L. Trubowitz, “Dead Center: The Demise of Liberal Internationalism in the United States,” *International Security* 32, no. 2 (2007): 7–44; Peter Hays Gries, *The Politics of American Foreign Policy: How Ideology Divides Liberals and Conservatives over Foreign Affairs* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2014); Gyung-Ho Jeong and Paul J. Quirk, “Division at the Water's Edge: The Polarization of Foreign Policy,” *American Politics Research* 47, no. 1 (2019): 58–87; Dina Smeltz, “Are We Drowning at the Water's Edge? Foreign Policy Polarization Among the US Public,” in *Polarization and US Foreign Policy: When Politics Crosses the Water's Edge*, ed. Gordon M. Friedrichs and Jordan Tama (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2024), 27–46.

³ Thomas Carothers and Andrew O'Donohue, “Introduction,” in *Democracies Divided: The Global Challenge of Political Polarization*, ed. Thomas Carothers and Andrew O'Donohue (Washington, DC: Brookings Institution Press, 2019), 1.

Scholars have documented numerous negative effects of polarization on society and governance, including the coarsening of political discourse,⁴ weakening of social cohesion,⁵ creation of policymaking gridlock,⁶ and erosion of democratic norms and institutions.⁷ Researchers have also identified harmful effects of polarization on the making of foreign policy,⁸ including the placement of partisan interests above the national interest⁹; weakening of constraints on executive power¹⁰; politicization of the military¹¹; creation of large swings in foreign policy from one leader to the next¹²; erosion of a country's ability to sustain major international investments¹³; reduction of support for liberal internationalism¹⁴; politicization of international negotiations¹⁵; tainting of a country's reputation as a reliable partner¹⁶; weakening of the credibility of a country's deterrence posture¹⁷; limiting of a country's ability to learn from foreign policy mistakes¹⁸; and incentivization of foreign interventions in a country's electoral processes.¹⁹ Aware of many of these harmful effects, U.S. foreign policy professionals have rated polarization as the most critical threat to the United States.²⁰

⁴ Liliana Mason, *Uncivil Agreement: How Politics Became Our Identity* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2018).

⁵ Jennifer McCoy, Tahmina Rahman and Murat Somer, "Polarization and the Global Crisis of Democracy: Common Patterns, Dynamics, and Pernicious Consequences for Democratic Polities," *American Behavioral Scientist* 62, no. 1 (2018): 16–42.

⁶ Sarah Binder, *Stalemate: Causes and Consequences of Legislative Gridlock* (Washington, DC: Brookings Institution Press, 2003).

⁷ Ekim Arbatli and Dina Rosenberg, "United We Stand, Divided We Rule: How Political Polarization Erodes Democracy," *Democratization* 28, no. 2 (2021): 285–307; Nathan P. Kalmoe and Liliana Mason, *Radical American Partisanship: Mapping Violent Hostility, Its Causes, and the Consequences for Democracy* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2022).

⁸ Kenneth A. Schultz, "Perils of Polarization for US Foreign Policy," *Washington Quarterly* 40, no. 4 (2017): 7–28; Gordon M. Friedrichs and Jordan Tama, eds., *Polarization and US Foreign Policy: When Politics Crosses the Water's Edge* (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2024).

⁹ Paul R. Pillar, *Beyond the Water's Edge: How Partisanship Corrupts U.S. Foreign Policy* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2023).

¹⁰ Daniel W. Drezner and Elizabeth N. Saunders, "Trump's Year of Anarchy: The Unconstrained Presidency and the End of American Primacy," *Foreign Affairs*, 20 January 2026, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/united-states/trumps-year-anarchy>; Susan D. Hyde and Elizabeth N. Saunders, "The Unconstrained Future of World Order: The Assault on Democratic Constraint and Implications for US Global Leadership," *International Organization* 79, Supplement (2025): S71–S87.

¹¹ Peter D. Feaver, *Thanks for Your Service: The Causes and Consequences of Public Confidence in the US Military* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2023); Michael A. Robinson, *Dangerous Instrument: Political Polarization and US Civil-Military Relations* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2023).

¹² Schultz, "Perils of Polarization for US Foreign Policy."

¹³ Stephen M. Walt, "America's Polarization Is a Foreign Policy Problem, Too," *Foreign Policy*, 11 March 2019, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://foreignpolicy.com/2019/03/11/americas-polarization-is-a-foreign-policy-problem-too/>.

¹⁴ Kupchan and Trubowitz. "Dead Center."

¹⁵ Gordon M. Friedrichs, "Conceptualizing the Effects of Polarization for US Foreign Policy Behavior in International Negotiations: Revisiting the Two-Level Game," *International Studies Review* 24, no. 1 (2022): viac010; Jeffrey S. Peake, *Dysfunctional Diplomacy: The Politics of International Agreements in an Era of Partisan Polarization* (New York: Routledge, 2023).

¹⁶ Rachel Myrick, "The Reputational Consequences of Polarization for American Foreign Policy: Evidence from the US-UK Bilateral Relationship," in *Polarization and US Foreign Policy: When Politics Crosses the Water's Edge*, eds, Gordon M. Friedrichs and Jordan Tama (Cham: Palgrave Macmillan, 2024), 373–403; Florian Böller and Jakob Wiedekind, "The Declining Reliability of U.S. Foreign Policy and Its Domestic Sources under Trump II," *Zeitschrift für Außen-und Sicherheitspolitik* 18 (2025): 577–87.

¹⁷ Helen Webley-Brown and Lauren Sukin, "Divisions at Home, Broken Promises Abroad? How Domestic Politics Shapes the United States' Nuclear Credibility," *International Studies Quarterly* 70, no. 2 (2026), <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqag023>.

¹⁸ Schultz, "Perils of Polarization for US Foreign Policy."

¹⁹ Schultz, "Perils of Polarization for US Foreign Policy."

²⁰ Dina Smeltz, Joshua Busby, and Jordan Tama, "Political Polarization the Critical Threat to US, Foreign Policy Experts Say," *The Hill*, 9 November 2018, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://thehill.com/opinion/national-security/415881-political-polarization-is-the-critical-threat-to-us-foreign-policy/>.

Yet until now, scholars of international politics have been lacking a broader conceptual framework for understanding the ways in which polarization alters the foreign policy of democracies. Rachel Myrick provides this framework and demonstrates its analytical power in *Polarization and International Politics: How Extreme Partisanship Threatens Global Stability*.²¹ The book is not only the most important work to date on the relationship between polarization and international relations, it is also one of the best books that has been written on the domestic politics of foreign policy more generally.

Myrick begins by offering clear and helpful definitions of polarization, noting the distinction between ideological polarization, which involves division over policy preferences, and affective polarization, which involves interpersonal ill will. Bringing together these key components of polarization, Myrick defines “extreme polarization” as “political environments in which ideological and affective polarization coincide.”²² She further explains how extreme polarization leads partisan conflict to spread into more policy domains (including foreign affairs).

The major theoretical innovation of *Polarization and International Politics* centers on Myrick’s engagement with the large existing literature on the advantages that democracies tend to possess in world affairs.²³ As Myrick usefully summarizes, this literature has shown that “democracies tend to keep foreign policy relatively stable across time, credibly signal information to adversaries, and reliably maintain commitments to allies.”²⁴ Myrick’s key insight is to distinguish between how lower and higher levels of polarization affect these typical democratic advantages. Low to moderate levels of polarization, she notes, reinforce democratic advantages—for instance, by allowing leaders to use the stances of opposition politicians to extract more concessions from international counterparts in negotiations. But extreme polarization erodes these democratic advantages by generating greater policy change from one leader to the next, making it harder for leaders to follow through on promises and threats, and increasing the likelihood that future leaders will renege on the commitments of prior leaders.

Myrick also offers a rich account of how extreme polarization weakens democratic constraints, including both vertical constraints that come from the public and horizontal constraints that come from other political actors and institutions. She writes: “A highly polarized public is less able to hold leaders accountable because partisans are unlikely to acknowledge situations when their own team does something wrong or the other team does something right. Likewise, the political opposition is a less reliable check on executive power because it has incentives to consistently oppose or undermine the executive.”²⁵

Myrick marshals a tremendous array of evidence to support her argument. Her impressive empirical strategy begins with the cross-national analysis of an original dataset she created of the platforms of governing and opposition parties and coalitions. These data clearly

²¹ Rachel Myrick, *Polarization and International Politics: How Extreme Partisanship Threatens Global Stability* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2025).

²² Myrick, *Polarization and International Politics*, 3.

²³ See, for example, James D. Fearon, “Domestic Political Audiences and the Escalation of International Disputes,” *American Political Science Review* 88, no. 3 (1994): 577–92; Kenneth A. Schultz, *Democracy and Coercive Diplomacy* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001); Brett Ashley Leeds, Michaela Mattes, and Jeremy S. Vogel, “Interests, Institutions, and the Reliability of International Commitments,” *American Journal of Political Science* 53, no. 2 (2009): 461–76; Dan Reiter and Allan C. Stam, “Democracies Have an Edge in Fighting Wars,” *Foreign Affairs*, 7 May 2020, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/world/2020-05-07/democracies-have-edge-fighting-wars>; Brett Ashley Leeds and Michaela Mattes, *Domestic Interests, Diplomacy, and Foreign Policy Change* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022).

²⁴ Myrick, *Polarization and International Politics*, 4–5. But see also Joshua D. Kertzer, Jonathan Renshon, and Keren Yarhi-Milo, “How Do Observers Assess Resolve?,” *British Journal of Political Science* 51, no. 1 (2021): 308–30, which finds that people tend to consider democracies to have less resolve than autocracies.

²⁵ Myrick, *Polarization and International Politics*, 14.

indicate that the size of the gaps separating the positions of governing and opposition parties increased in many countries during the first quarter of the twenty-first century, reinforcing the growing understanding that polarization is not limited to a small number of countries. Based on the data, Myrick further shows that when democracies are more polarized, they have more volatile foreign policy positions (as measured by their United Nations voting records), are less credible in international disputes (as measured by how other countries react to them during militarized disputes), and are more likely to renege on international commitments (as measured by whether they violate alliance agreements).

Having established these patterns cross-nationally, Myrick then provides a more in-depth analysis of the effects of polarization on U.S. foreign policy. Here she draws on original survey experiments, first-person interviews of executive branch and congressional officials, public opinion data, and congressional speech and voting records to generate a series of additional findings that buttress her argument. One of her most striking findings is that many Americans today support legislators in their party obstructing a president from the other party from carrying out foreign policy decisions. Myrick also shows that foreign policy issues are more susceptible to polarization when they involve nontraditional security threats or can be easily linked to aspects of social identity that are correlated with partisan identity.

Myrick effectively illustrates some of the pathologies that follow from polarization through a case study of President Barack Obama's negotiation of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) with Iran. In this analysis, she shows that the widespread Republican opposition to the negotiation with Iran, which was fueled by partisan objectives, led Obama to treat the agreement as an executive agreement that did not require Senate confirmation. While this decision allowed Obama to begin implementing the JCPOA, it made the agreement less durable, making it easy for President Donald Trump to pull out of it. For foreign leaders observing this episode, a clear takeaway was that negotiating complex issues with the United States may not be worth the trouble.

Extensions

Beyond its compelling findings, *Polarization and International Politics* provides much food for thought for further analysis, including regarding different foreign policy scenarios. For instance, although Myrick shows that extreme polarization makes it harder for leaders to carry out promises and threats, one can imagine that diminished domestic constraints on a leader might sometimes actually heighten the credibility of their threats, because weakened constraints may mean no political actor can stop them from following through. More specifically, in a context of low to moderate polarization, a leader who threatens to initiate a risky war of choice might be blocked or dissuaded from carrying out the military action by opposition from legislators across the political spectrum. However, in a context of extreme polarization, the leader's co-partisans would probably back the leader and the legislature, therefore, might be less likely to stand in the leader's way. Consideration of scenarios where increased polarization might enhance the credibility of a leader's threats could add further nuance to Myrick's analytical framework.

I also wondered while reading *Polarization and International Politics* if declines in a country's reliability can reach a tipping point when allies and partners turn away from the country in an enduring way. Myrick's work shows that extreme polarization damages a country's international reputation, but to what extent or in what circumstances is this reputational damage long-lasting or permanent? Data on global attitudes toward the United States suggest that, at least through Joe Biden's administration, reputational damage incurred during one U.S. administration has been (at least largely) reversible during

subsequent U.S. administrations. Over the past quarter-century, the Pew Research Center has asked residents of many countries, in annual surveys, whether they have a favorable or unfavorable view of the United States. For residents of some of these countries, particularly in Europe, Pew's data show that attitudes have fluctuated greatly from one U.S. administration to the next, from unfavorable ratings during the George W. Bush administration, to favorable ratings during the Barack Obama administration, to unfavorable ratings during the first Trump administration, to favorable ratings during the Biden administration, to unfavorable ratings during the second Trump administration.²⁶ Gallup data from surveys of people in more than 130 countries asking them whether they approve or disapprove of the job performance of the leadership of the United States also reveal considerable fluctuations from one U.S. administration to the next over the past 20 years.²⁷ While favorability and approval ratings are not the same as perceptions of reliability, these fluctuations point to the malleability of a country's reputation depending on the country's leader at a given time.

But a country's reputation may sometimes take such a large hit that the damage is enduring. Indeed, the reputation of the United States may have recently reached such a tipping point as a result of the particularly aggressive and unilateral policies of the second Trump administration. Consistent with Myrick's analysis, extreme polarization has enabled this state of affairs by eroding the guardrails that otherwise might have constrained Trump's very expansive exercise of executive power.²⁸ In indications that reputational decline this time may have more far-reaching and lasting effects, many longtime U.S. allies and partners are now developing and advancing alternatives to reliance in the United States in both security and economic affairs.²⁹ But it remains an open question to what extent such derisking or decoupling efforts will continue if Trump is succeeded by a president who works to restore America's frayed relationships—and this, too, is an important subject for future research.

The discipline of political science is also ripe for deeper investigation of the relationships between polarization and several related phenomena, including politicization, populism, and democratic erosion. Politicization, in one standard definition, refers to the “demand for, or the act of, transporting an issue or an institution into the sphere of politics—making previously unpolitical matters political.”³⁰ Politicization is closely connected to polarization in that high levels of polarization incentivize elected officials to politicize issues, and acts of politicization, in turn, foster greater polarization.³¹ In one indication of this symbiotic relationship, foreign policy issues have become more politicized in recent years in many

²⁶ Richard Wike, Janell Fetterolf, Maria Smerkovich, Sarah Austin, and Sofia Hernandez Ramones, “Globally, Biden Receives High Ratings than Trump,” Pew Research Center, 11 June 2024, p. 35, accessed 15 May 2026, https://www.pewresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/sites/20/2024/06/gap_2024.06.11_us-image-2024_report.pdf; Richard Wike, Jacob Poushter, Laura Silver, and Janell Fetterolf, “U.S. Image Declines in Many Nations amid Low Confidence in Trump,” Pew Research Center, 11 June 2025, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://www.pewresearch.org/global/2025/06/11/views-of-the-united-states/>.

²⁷ Julie Ray, Benedict Vigers and Zaccary Ritter, “China Edges Past U.S. in Global Approval Ratings,” *Gallup*, 3 April 2026, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://news.gallup.com/poll/707945/china-edges-past-global-approval-ratings.aspx>.

²⁸ Hyde and Saunders, “The Unconstrained Future of World Order”; Drezner and Saunders, “Trump's Year of Anarchy.”

²⁹ Nicolas Vinocur and Zoya Sheftalovich, “Europe Begins Its Slow Retreat from US Dependence,” *Politico*, 2 February 2026, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://www.politico.eu/article/europe-begins-retreat-united-states-dependence-donald-trump-rocks-transatlantic-relationship/>; Ned Temko, “In Response to Trump's Foreign Policy Strategy, US Allies try ‘De-Risking’,” *Christian Science Monitor*, 19 February 2026, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://www.csmonitor.com/World/2026/0219/trump-america-first-nato-derisking#:~:text=Why%20We%20Wrote%20This,overhaul%20of%20U.S.%20foreign%20policy>.

³⁰ Michael Zürn, “Politicization Compared: At National, European, and Global Levels,” *Journal of European Public Policy* 26, no. 7 (2019): 977–78.

³¹ Katja Biedenkopf, Oriol Costa, and Magdalena Góra, “Introduction: Shades of Contestation and Politicization of CFSP,” *European Security* 30, no. 3 (2021): 325–43.

Populism, which is also increasingly shaping the foreign policy of many countries, is another important related phenomenon.³³ Populists fuel politicization and polarization by taking highly adversarial stances toward political opponents, using policy debates to mobilize political supporters, and asserting personalized control of government institutions.³⁴ At the same time, high levels of polarization facilitate populism because it is easier for leaders to pit one part of society against another when the society is already divided.

It will also be worth considering the extent to which some of the pathologies highlighted by Myrick characterize countries that are not just backsliding in terms of democracy but are solidly authoritarian. Polarization can be strong in authoritarian countries; in such countries, however, one would expect polarization to be manifest in enduring conflict between supporters and opponents of the ruling regime, rather than the alternation of power between parties with strongly opposing views. How might such enduring polarization between regime supporters and opponents affect the conduct of a country's foreign policy, and would such polarization generate any of the same dysfunctions as those prevalent in polarized democracies?

Shifting from political dynamics within countries to dynamics between countries, the discipline of political science would also benefit from new research on the extent to which countries are aligning with or against one another along the same faultlines that characterize their domestic politics. To the extent this is happening today, it would appear to pit countries ruled by right-wing populist governments against countries ruled by governments with stronger commitments to liberal norms. Certainly there are signs of a growing global divide along this fault line. In recent years, right-wing populist leaders like Donald Trump, former Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban, and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu have cooperated with each other to advance their shared illiberal vision of politics, while

³³ Angelos Chrysosgelos, "Populism in Foreign Policy," *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics* (Online only, 2017), accessed 15 May 2026, <https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190228637.013.467>; Sandra Destradi and Johannes Plagemann, *Populism and Foreign Policy* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2025).

³⁵ Jennifer McCoy, Tahmina Rahman, and Murat Somer, “Polarization and the Global Crisis of Democracy: Common Patterns, Dynamics, and Pernicious Consequences For Democratic Polities,” *American Behavioral Scientist* 62, no. 1 (2018): 16–42; Ekim Arbatli and Dina Rosenberg, “United We Stand, Divided We Rule: How Political Polarization Erodes Democracy,” *Democratization* 28, no. 2 (2021): 285–307.

³⁶ Lydia Khalil, Peter Woodrow, James Paterson, and Robert Kaufman, “Understanding Democratic Erosion,” *Lowy Institute*, July 2025, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://interactives.lowyinstitute.org/features/democratic-erosion/>.

leaders such as Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney, French President Emmanuel Macron, and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz have aligned with each other to counter the right-wing populist push and protect liberal values.

Yet many national governments do not clearly fit in one or the other of these camps, and in some regions of the world, key faultlines have different characteristics. In Southeast Asia, for instance, many major political debates concern how countries might position themselves with respect to the United States and China, and many governments in this region are opting to hedge their bets rather than throw in their lot entirely with one or the other major power.³⁷ More broadly, some research suggests the world is growing more diverse politically, rather than being distilled into a small number of competing camps. Amitav Acharya argues that we live increasingly in a multiplex world order in which a wide array of state and nonstate actors interact “based on a plurality of ideas and approaches.”³⁸ Further study of the ways in which political debates and relationships are polarizing or diversifying cross-nationally represents one of the most exciting avenues for polarization-related research in the years ahead.

Remedies

The critical practical question raised by any study of polarization is: what can be done to mitigate or reverse it? Myrick offers an excellent overview of possible remedies for polarization in the conclusion of *Polarization and International Politics*. Focusing on the United States, she helpfully groups possible remedies in three sets: (1) strategies to insulate foreign policy issues from polarization, (2) strategies to reduce polarization among members of Congress more generally, and (3) strategies to reduce polarization among members of the public.³⁹

Regarding the first set of approaches, Myrick notes that strategies of insulation can include decisions by political leaders to refrain from engaging in partisan warfare on foreign policy issues, efforts by officials to keep foreign policy debates out of the media limelight, and institutional reforms designed to bolster the nonpartisan character of foreign policy institutions. Indeed, some other work shows that political actors have sometimes been effective at minimizing polarization by minimizing the public salience of a policy issue. Specifically, supporters of foreign aid spend preserved bipartisan backing for the foreign aid budget over a period of decades by having those debates play out largely behind the scenes on Capitol Hill, rather than in front of television cameras.⁴⁰ But, as Myrick points out, such strategies of political insulation are always highly vulnerable because some elected officials will be tempted to politicize an issue for partisan gain. Indeed, Trump politicized foreign aid policy at the start of his second term, thereby making stances in this policy area more polarized.⁴¹ Ultimately, strategies of insulation are only as effective as the goodwill and

³⁷ Ann Marie Murphy, “Great Power Rivalries, Domestic Politics and Southeast Asian Foreign Policy: Exploring the Linkages,” *Asian Security* 13, no. 3 (2017): 165–82; Jonathan Stromseth, *Don't Make Us Choose: Southeast Asia in the Throes of US-China Rivalry* (Washington, DC: Brookings Institution, 2019); Cheng-Chwee Kuik, “Southeast Asian Responses to US-China Tech Competition: Hedging and Economy-Security Tradeoffs,” *Journal of Chinese Political Science* 29, no. 3 (2024): 509–38.

³⁸ Amitav Acharya, “Thinking Beyond a Polarized World: Why Multiplexity Matters,” *International Affairs* 102, no. 2 (2026): 503–11, 504.

³⁹ Myrick, *Polarization and International Politics*, 262–76.

⁴⁰ Jordan Tama, *Bipartisanship and US Foreign Policy: Cooperation in a Polarized Age* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2024), 189–212.

⁴¹ Jordan Tama, “From Insulation to Politicization: How Leaders and Civil Society Have Shaped the Politics of U.S. Foreign Aid Policy,” (International Studies Association Annual Convention, Chicago, IL, 2–5 March 2025).

commitment of the leaders responsible for carrying them out. In a polarized era, such goodwill and commitment are hard to sustain.

With respect to approaches intended to limit polarization among elected officials more generally, Myrick outlines a variety of potential electoral reforms, including the adoption of proportional representation, the establishment of open primaries, the elimination of partisan drawing of congressional districts, and greater restrictions on the role of outside money in politics. If adopted, these types of reforms might limit polarization a great deal.⁴² But as Myrick observes, they are very difficult politically to institute because they threaten the power of existing office holders and party leaders.

Finally, Myrick considers strategies for reducing polarization among members of the public, such as efforts to expose people to more fellow citizens with different political perspectives, provide people with information that corrects misperceptions about members of the other party, or highlight social identities (e.g., shared affinities for certain sports teams) that are shared across party lines. While some of these strategies have been found to be effective in reducing polarization among groups of individuals,⁴³ Myrick notes it is difficult to scale them up to the national level. To do so, it would probably be necessary to have them incorporated into the curricula of many schools, which would require concerted advocacy across the country at the state and local levels. Strategies centered on exposing people to information that counters stereotypes about members of the other party also face the very powerful headwinds generated by social media algorithms that propagate such stereotypes ad nauseam.⁴⁴ Weakening these headwinds would require social media companies to alter their algorithms so highly partisan messages get less attention on their platforms—a change that might require robust government regulation.⁴⁵

Aside from proactive strategies for reversing polarization, there also exists the possibility that events will reverse the phenomenon. One long-standing truism in political science is that national security crises generate a “rally ‘round the flag” effect that reduces contestation between political parties.⁴⁶ This last occurred to a large degree in the United States in the immediate aftermath of the 11 September 2001 terrorist attacks, when 90 percent of the American public approved of President George W. Bush’s performance.⁴⁷ But that rally did not last long, and views of Bush’s presidency became sharply polarized in subsequent years.⁴⁸

⁴² Nathaniel Persily, ed., *Solutions to Political Polarization in America* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2015); Lee Drutman, *Breaking the Two-Party Doom Loop: The Case for Multiparty Democracy in America* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2020); Benjamin I. Page, and Martin Gilens, *Democracy in America?: What Has Gone Wrong and What We Can Do About It* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2020).

⁴³ See Matthew Levendusky, *Our Common Bonds: Using What Americans Share to Help Bridge the Partisan Divide* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2023) Sara B. Hobolt, Katharina Lawall, and James Tilley, “The Polarizing Effect of Partisan Echo Chambers,” *American Political Science Review* 118, no. 3 (2024): 1464–79.

⁴⁴ Emily Kubin and Christian Von Sikorski, “The Role of (Social) Media in Political Polarization: A Systematic Review,” *Annals of the International Communication Association* 45, no. 3 (2021): 188–206.

⁴⁵ Peter J. Benson, Valerie C. Brannon, Victoria L. Killion, Ling Zhu, “Social Media: Regulatory, Legal, and Policy Considerations for the 119th Congress,” *Congressional Research Service*, 11 February 2025, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/IF12904> file:///C:/Users/jorda/Downloads/IF12904.1.pdf.

⁴⁶ John E. Mueller, “Presidential Popularity from Truman to Johnson,” *American Political Science Review* 64, no. 1 (1970): 18–34; William D. Baker and John R. Oneal, “Patriotism or Opinion Leadership? The Nature and Origins of the ‘Rally ‘Round the Flag’ Effect,” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 45, no. 5 (2001): 661–87; Matthew A. Baum, “The Constituent Foundations of the Rally-Round-The-Flag Phenomenon,” *International Studies Quarterly* 46, no. 2 (2002): 263–98.

⁴⁷ David W. Moore, “Bush Job Approval Highest in Gallup History,” *Gallup News Service*, 24 September 2001, accessed 15 May 2026, <https://news.gallup.com/poll/4924/bush-job-approval-highest-gallup-history.aspx>.

⁴⁸ Cindy D. Kam and Jennifer M. Ramos, “Joining and Leaving the Rally: Understanding the Surge and Decline in Presidential Approval Following 9/11,” *Public Opinion Quarterly* 72, no. 4 (2008): 619–50.

A separate study by Myrick suggested additional caution about the expectation that a national security threat could remedy the polarization problem. Through analysis of congressional speeches, public opinion polls, and an original survey experiment, Myrick found that the international threat environment—including the prospect of a heightened security threat from China—has little effect on polarization when the domestic context is already highly politicized.⁴⁹ Other recent work reinforces and extends this finding. Joshua Schwartz and Dominic Tierney showed that a vivid foreign threat from China only reduces polarization among the public if there exists bipartisan agreement about the threat among elites,⁵⁰ and Yuval Feinstein and Geffen Ben-David showed that the high levels of polarization in Israel prevented a rally effect after the 7 October 2023 Hamas attack on that country.⁵¹

Conclusion

Ultimately, there is not a silver bullet for reversing polarization, and every conceivable strategy for reducing it has limitations or faces major obstacles to implementation. But this should not be a reason for throwing up one's hands, because the collective pursuit of a variety of strategies by constellations of groups and concerned citizens has the potential to make some gradual—however insufficient—progress on this extremely important challenge.⁵² An optimist might also feel compelled to point out that there remains the possibility, however unlikely it may seem today, that growing numbers of citizens will come to recognize the harms caused by polarization and support political campaigns that seek to bring politics back from the brink. In her outstanding book, Myrick suggests such a movement may be necessary not only to restore effective representative governance at home but also to enable democracies to be successful again on the world stage.

⁴⁹ Rachel Myrick, "Do External Threats Unite or Divide? Security Crises, Rivalries, and Polarization in American Foreign Policy," *International Organization* 75, no. 4 (2021): 921–58.

⁵⁰ Joshua A. Schwartz and Dominic Tierney, "Us and Them: Foreign Threat and Domestic Polarization," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 69, no. 2–3 (2025): 352–80.

⁵¹ Yuval Feinstein and Geffen Ben-David, "United or Divided? A Polarized Society's Response to War," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 90, no. 3 (2026): 657–96.

⁵² Rachel Kleinfeld, "Polarization, Democracy, and Political Violence in the United States: What the Research Says" (Washington, DC: Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, September 2023), accessed 15 May 2026, https://assets.carnegieendowment.org/static/files/Kleinfeld_Polarization_final_3.pdf.